

Rippl

Financial what-if simulator

Full app description & launch plan

May 2026

1. The idea

Most people make the biggest financial decisions of their lives — changing jobs, buying a home, going freelance, having children — with almost no visibility into what those decisions actually mean for their money. Spreadsheets are too complex. Generic calculators are too simplistic. Financial advisers are too expensive.

Rippl fills that gap. It is a mobile app that lets users model any major life event as a financial scenario and see, in plain English, exactly what happens to their take-home pay, savings rate, tax burden, and long-term wealth. Not vague guidance — a specific, personalised projection.

The core mechanic is the "what if" — two columns, side by side: your life now, and your life if you make the change. Every number the user cares about is calculated and explained, including ones they didn't think to ask about.

2. The name — Rippl

Rippl captures the core truth of personal finance: every major decision sends ripples through your entire financial life — your take-home pay, your savings rate, your tax bill, your long-term wealth. The dropped final 'e' keeps it clean and app-native. The name is short, visual, and immediately understood without needing explanation. It feels calm and intelligent — not clinical, not gamified.

Tagline: "See your financial future before you decide."

3. Market opportunity

Market size

\$1.5B

Target price

£7–12/mo

MVP timeline

8 weeks

Build cost

£15–30k

The personal finance app market is worth \$1.5 billion and growing. But the existing apps — Monzo, Emma, Cleo, MoneyHelper — are all backwards-looking. They show you what you spent last month. None of them help you plan forward around a specific life decision.

The UK is an underserved market. Most serious finance tools are built for US tax rules. Rippl is built from the ground up for UK users: PAYE, National Insurance, ISA limits, stamp duty, Child Benefit taper — all baked in. This is a genuine competitive moat that US-first apps cannot easily replicate.

4. Target users

Primary: Decision-makers, 25–45

Professionals facing a major life event in the next 12 months — a job change, property purchase, or career pivot. They are comfortable with technology, underserved by generic calculators, and would pay for clarity. They do not want a financial adviser for every decision.

Secondary: Planners and the financially anxious

People who run financial scenarios for fun, or who feel anxious about money and want a tool that makes uncertainty feel manageable. This group drives word-of-mouth and app store ratings.

Tertiary: Freelancers and the self-employed

A growing segment with uniquely complex finances — irregular income, self-assessment tax, no employer pension. Mainstream apps ignore them. Rippl's freelance scenario module speaks directly to their needs.

5. Core scenarios

Each scenario is a self-contained module in the app with pre-configured input fields, a UK tax engine, and a results view. All six are included in the MVP.

Scenario	What the app models
New job offer	Compare salary, tax, NI, commute costs, pension — net monthly gain/loss
Buy a home	Model mortgage repayments, stamp duty, deposit impact, vs renting
Go freelance	Irregular income planning, self-assessment tax, emergency fund runway
Have a child	Childcare costs, maternity/paternity pay, Child Benefit, career break impact
Early retirement	Pension drawdown rates, ISA runway, state pension gap, safe

	withdrawal
Big purchase	Car, renovation, holiday — savings timeline and opportunity cost

6. Product features

MVP (version 1.0)

- Scenario picker — six life event types, chip-style navigation
- Two-panel input form — current situation on the left, the what-if on the right
- UK tax engine — PAYE, National Insurance, ISA rules, pension tax relief
- 12-month cash flow chart — side-by-side bar chart, now vs what-if
- Line-by-line comparison table — every variable explained
- AI plain-English summary — powered by Claude, reads like advice from a financially literate friend
- Save and name a scenario — revisit it later
- Share a scenario link — send to a partner or friend for a second opinion

Version 2.0 (post-launch)

- Open Banking sync via TrueLayer — auto-fill current income and expenses
- Reverse mode — "what salary do I need to afford this mortgage?"
- Multi-scenario comparison — run up to three side by side
- 5-year projection view — see compound effects over time
- Life event alerts — push notifications when interest rates or tax thresholds change that affect a saved scenario
- Family mode — model joint finances for couples

7. UI design principles

Rippl should feel like a thoughtful, calm tool — not a gamified finance app. The design language is clean and minimal: white surfaces, precise typography, restrained use of the brand purple. The visual hierarchy always puts the user's decision at the centre.

- Purple accent (#534AB7) for the what-if state — the change is always visually distinct from the baseline
- Green for improvements, red for costs — instant emotional read at a glance
- The AI summary panel uses a soft purple background to signal intelligence, not a chatbot
- No dark patterns, no nudges toward premium upsells in results screens

8. Tech stack

Layer	Technology
Frontend	React Native — single codebase for iOS and Android

Backend	Node.js + Express — REST API
Database	PostgreSQL — user data, saved scenarios
Tax engine	Custom UK module — PAYE, NI, ISA, pension rules
AI summaries	Anthropic Claude API — plain-English results
Open Banking	TrueLayer — bank sync (phase 2)
Payments	Stripe — subscription billing
Hosting	Railway or Vercel — low-ops, cost-efficient

9. Monetisation

Rippl uses a freemium subscription model. The free tier is genuinely useful — enough for a user to run their first scenario and see the value — but limited enough that regular users upgrade.

Free tier 3 saved scenarios Manual data entry only 12-month view Basic AI summary	Pro — £9/month Unlimited scenarios Bank sync (phase 2) 5-year projections Full AI insights + alerts
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10. Launch roadmap

Phase 1 Validate Weeks 1–3	• Build a landing page with a beta signup form • Run targeted ads on Reddit (r/UKPersonalFinance) and LinkedIn • Manually run 10–15 scenarios for early signups to prove the concept works • Interview 20 users — confirm the six scenario types are correct • Target: 200 waitlist signups and 3 pre-sales before building
Phase 2 Build MVP Weeks 4–11	• Build the React Native app skeleton and navigation • Build the UK tax engine module (PAYE, NI, pension, ISA) • Build all six scenario input forms and results views • Integrate Claude API for AI plain-English summaries • Internal QA and beta testing with 20 waitlist users
Phase 3 Beta launch Weeks 12–16	• Soft launch to waitlist — free Pro for 60 days • Collect feedback via in-app prompts and weekly user interviews • Fix top 10 issues before public launch • App Store and Google Play submission • PR push — target MoneySavingExpert forum and UK personal finance Twitter/X
Phase 4	• Open Banking sync via TrueLayer — auto-fill income and expenses

Scale Month 5+	• Launch reverse mode and multi-scenario comparison • Affiliate partnerships with mortgage brokers and IFAs • Introduce annual plan (£79/year — saves 27% vs monthly) • Target 1,000 paying subscribers by month 9
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11. Key risks & mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Financial advice boundary	App shows projections only — not advice. Clear FCA-compliant disclaimers on every results screen. Legal review before launch.
Open Banking complexity	Skip TrueLayer in the MVP entirely. Manual entry first. Add bank sync only after proving users will pay.
Strong incumbents	Win on the what-if framing — no existing app does this. Focus on the UK market where US-first tools are weakest.
Low retention	Build life-event push alerts to re-engage users when tax rules change. Saved scenarios pull people back.
Tax rule changes	Modular tax engine designed to be updated each tax year. Budget update coverage is a PR opportunity.

12. Success metrics

- **Validation:** 200 waitlist signups before build begins
- **Month 1:** 50 paying Pro subscribers within 30 days of public launch
- **Month 9:** 1,000 paying subscribers, 4.2+ App Store rating, <5% monthly churn
- **Year 2:** 10,000 paying subscribers, explore B2B / IFA white-label version

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This document is confidential and intended for internal planning purposes.